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Léa

October 1943

Léa, sitting next to Rose in the third-class passenger carriage, stiffened at the throng of soldiers and police at Berlin's Anhalter station. When the sisters stepped down from the train, it was as if the midday sun had disappeared behind a cloud. The platform was as dark as a bruise. Léa pointed at the camouflage net covering the roof and stretching over the many tracks. On the opposite platform, a train with a red cross painted on a white background was parked. Bandaged soldiers stepped off it while medical workers unloaded endless numbers of wounded soldiers on stretchers.

News of the Wehrmacht's defeat at Stalingrad, then at Kursk had cast a different light on the seemingly invincible power of the German army. Josef believed both losses marked a turning point in the war. *They won't recover from this; now it's just a matter of how long and how bloody until they're crushed.* It was the bloody part that worried everyone. As the army retreated, it rounded up Polish and Russian citizens forcing them to come with them. It almost seemed like the Wehrmacht were taunting their enemies to chase after them and collect the booty they'd stolen on their retreat.

On the bright side, though Léa hesitated to think about it that way, was Rose's connection to Herr Reinhardt. The Reichsmarks he provided augmented the sick bay's resources, allowing them to purchase equipment, medicine, and food from farmers who sold their milk, cheese and meat on the black market. Supplementing Maria's rations had made a huge difference in her and her baby's health. Now, the malnourished Polish